CLEVER: A Portuguese Dataset for Claim Detection and Verification in Election News

Annotation Manual

Version 1.0 | November 2026

Purificação Silvano[1,3] · Gabriel Lázaro[2] · Raquel Sequeira[2] · Sara Nerea[2] · Inês Cantante[1] · Ricardo Campos[2,3]

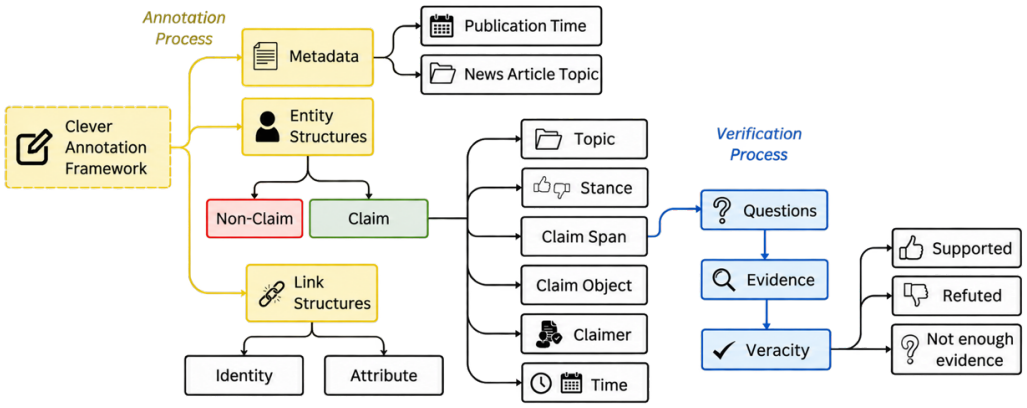
[1] University of Porto, Porto, Portugal
[2] University of Beira Interior, Covilhã, Portugal
[3] INESC TEC, Porto, Portugal

1. Purpose and scope

The growing proliferation of online content and limited newsroom resources increasingly challenge journalists seeking factual accuracy and timely verification, highlighting the need for automated fact-checking solutions. Manual verification remains labor-intensive, which underscores the growing need for automated resources. However, most existing political datasets are predominantly in English and focus narrowly on claim detection, leaving comprehensive verification in other languages largely unexplored. To bridge this gap, we introduce CLEVER, a new dataset in European Portuguese centered on the 2025 Portuguese legislative elections. The dataset features 228 news articles that underwent rigorous manual claim detection and verification. Data collection was conducted in collaboration with LUSA, the Portuguese News Agency, ensuring alignment with professional journalistic standards. By providing a structured, high-quality dataset in European Portuguese and annotation guidelines, CLEVER supports the development of automated fact-checking tools and strengthens newsroom verification workflows.

This manual guides annotators through the CLEVER workflow, from claim annotation and curation to verification question formulation, evidence retrieval, evidence annotation, and final claim classification.

2. Annotation scheme



3. Annotation units

Unit	Operational meaning
Claim span	The textual segment whose factual content is to be verified. Treat different spans separately.
Claim object	The central element or issue asserted about within the span.
Verification question	A factual information need formulated for one claim span.
Claim span–document pair	One claim span linked to one retrieved document. The unit for relevance and factual-relation annotation.
Evidence excerpt	A passage copied from the retrieved document that records the basis for a pair-level decision.
Claim-span label	The final result obtained by aggregating the factual relations of relevant pairs.

4. Annotation process

Complete the stages in this order: (1) claim annotation and curation; (2) verification question formulation and review; (3) evidence retrieval and consolidation; (4) relevance and evidence annotation; (5) claim-span classification and review. Keep each question, document, excerpt, and decision associated with the appropriate claim span.

5. Annotation guidelines

5.1. Claim annotation and curation

Follow the ClaimPT annotation manual for claim identification, span boundaries, attributes, and links. The present document extends that protocol and does not replace its detailed definitions. Read the complete article before annotating so that references and temporal expressions can be interpreted in context.

Consult the ClaimPT manual at https://github.com/LIAAD/ClaimPT/blob/main/ClaimPT%20Annotation%20Manual.pdf.

For CLEVER, two annotators perform claim annotation independently, followed by curation by a linguistics specialist. Use the curated claim spans and their associated claim objects, claimers, temporal information, and links as inputs to question formulation.

5.2. Verification question formulation

Formulate questions separately for each claim span. Every question must concern what that span asserts about its claim object. Where a claim contains several spans, produce an independent question set for each span.

5.2.1. Question coverage and specificity

Aim to formulate two complementary questions per span: a general question about the central theme of the claim object and a specific question targeting the concrete factual information requiring verification. These are complementary information needs, not a requirement to create redundant questions. If the proposition does not support two distinct questions, formulate one sufficiently informative question. For comparisons, separate the information needs necessary to obtain values for both comparison points.

For the general question, add the claimer, time, or context recovered through Attribute and Identity links when the claim object alone is insufficient. For the specific question, target relevant numbers, dates, measures, or institutions. Use Identity links to replace context-dependent references, such as “this system,” with the appropriate entity name.

5.2.2. Wording and contextual constraints

- Use neutral wording. Avoid subjective terms and presuppositions that favor confirmation or refutation. Replace “Why did the measure fail?” with “What was the outcome of measure X?”
- Maintain neutrality whether the annotated stance is Affirm or Refute. Focus on the alleged fact rather than the claimer’s opinion or belief.
- Include the relevant temporal boundary when Time is annotated or inferred through an Identity link to Publication Time.
- For local claims, identify the relevant region or territorial entity explicitly.
- Include the claimer when their authority is necessary to establish the validity of the asserted fact.
- For studies or reports, formulate the question to identify the specific document and locate the original source.
- Use other claim annotations when needed to interpret the assertion and locate evidence, but do not introduce unsupported contextual details.

5.2.3. Working procedure

1. Identify the claim span and check that its meaning can be interpreted in context.
2. Isolate its claim object, using the most specific relevant element within the span.
3. Resolve references and temporal information using the claimer, Time, Attribute links, Identity links, and article context.
4. Draft the general question and supply the context required to make it interpretable.
5. Draft the specific question where appropriate, or retain one question if a second would be redundant. Check that comparisons are adequately covered.

5.2.4. Question review

Each annotator formulates questions for an assigned group of claims. The other annotator reviews the questions and makes additions where needed. A linguistics specialist then conducts a final review for adherence to the guidelines, suitability for evidence retrieval, and linguistic correctness.

5.3. Evidence retrieval

5.3.1. Search collection and method

Submit each verification question independently to the internal search API over the LUSA News Corpus. The collection contains 1,346,032 documents published from January 1, 2016, to April 20, 2026. The API combines lexical retrieval using BM25 with semantic retrieval. Reciprocal Rank Fusion combines document positions in the two rankings into a single ranking (Cormack et al., 2009).

5.3.2. Temporal eligibility and selection

Retain only documents published before the publication date of the source article containing the claim. Retrieve the five highest-ranked eligible documents for each question. The cutoff is the source article's publication date. It must not be conflated with the date on which the original statement was made. Retrieval produces candidate evidence, not an automatic verification verdict.

5.3.3. Consolidation and traceability

When several questions for the same span retrieve the same document, consolidate them into one claim span–document pair and annotate the pair once. Retain the questions and retrieval positions associated with the document. Do not merge pairs that involve different claim spans: the same document may have a different relevance or factual relation for each span.

5.4. Document relevance annotation

Read each retrieved document in relation to the factual situation expressed by the claim span. Assign one relevance label before assessing support or refutation.

Label	Decision criterion	Next step
Relevant	The document contains information pertinent to the factual situation under verification.	Select excerpts and assign a factual relation.
Irrelevant	The document does not address that factual situation.	Exclude from evidence annotation and verdict aggregation.

Shared people, institutions, places, or topics are not sufficient to establish relevance. A relevant document need not support or refute the claim: it may address the situation while leaving the assertion unresolved.

Example

For “falou-se até de retirar poderes à direção executiva” (“there was even talk of removing powers from the Executive Directorate”), a document discussing the removal of powers from the SNS Executive Directorate is relevant. A document mentioning the same institution in an unrelated event is irrelevant, even if it uses similar terminology. Relevance alone does not establish that the alleged discussion occurred.

5.5. Evidence excerpts and factual relations

For every relevant pair, select one or more excerpts directly from the original document. Preserve the original wording and enough context to understand the decision. Multiple excerpts may belong to a single pair. Assign the factual-relation label to the pair, not independently to each excerpt.

Relation	Decision criterion
Supported	The evidence supplies factual information supporting what the claim span asserts about its claim object.
Refuted	The evidence supplies factual information contradicting that assertion.

Relation	Decision criterion
Not Enough Information (NEI)	The document addresses the factual situation but does not provide sufficient information to establish support or refutation.

Assess the assertion about the claim object. Do not assess the claimer's opinions, intentions, or credibility unless those features are necessary to verify the assertion. A relevant document labeled NEI is not an irrelevant document. Its excerpts record the pertinent information available, even though that information does not resolve the claim.

5.6. Claim span classification

Aggregate the relations of all relevant pairs associated with the same span. Apply the rules below to the available retrieved evidence. A final label does not establish that retrieval was exhaustive.

Relations among relevant pairs	Final label
At least one Supported and no Refuted	Supported
At least one Refuted and no Supported	Refuted
All relevant pairs are NEI	NEI
No relevant pairs are available	NEI
Both Supported and Refuted occur	NEI

NEI pairs do not override otherwise unopposed support or refutation. Where both support and refutation occur, assign NEI under the CLEVER aggregation scheme rather than selecting the majority relation. Pair-level NEI means insufficient information in one relevant document. Final NEI encompasses insufficient evidence, absence of relevant evidence, and conflicting evidence.

6. Quality control and completion checks

Evidence annotation and claim-span classification are performed by one annotator and checked in a second pass by the same annotator, as self-review or intra-annotator review. Use the following completion checklist when reviewing the annotation:

- Every question is attached to the correct curated span and claim object.

- Questions are neutral, interpretable, and appropriately grounded in time, place, and entities.
- Retrieved documents meet the publication cutoff and duplicate pairs have been consolidated.
- Relevance reflects the factual situation rather than topical or lexical overlap.
- Each relevant pair has its excerpt or excerpts and a factual-relation label. Irrelevant pairs do not contribute to the verdict.
- The final claim-span label follows the aggregation rules, including cases of no relevant evidence and conflicting evidence.
- Questions, retrieval positions, documents, excerpts, and labels remain traceable to their claim spans.

References

Campos, R., Sequeira, R., Nerea, S., Cantante, I., Folques, D., Cunha, F., Canavilhas, J., Branco, A., Jorge, A., Nunes, S., Guimarães, N., & Silvano, P. (2025). ClaimPT: A dataset for claim detection and fact-checking [Data set]. INESC TEC. https://doi.org/10.25747/JY10-E413

Cormack, G. V., Clarke, C. L. A., & Büttcher, S. (2009). Reciprocal rank fusion outperforms Condorcet and individual rank learning methods. In Proceedings of the 32nd international ACM SIGIR conference on research and development in information retrieval (pp. 758–759). Association for Computing Machinery. https://doi.org/10.1145/1571941.1572114

Schlichtkrull, M., Guo, Z., & Vlachos, A. (2023). AVeriTeC: A dataset for real-world claim verification with evidence from the web. Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems, 36. https://fever.ai/dataset/averitec.html

Silvano, P., Sequeira, R., Nerea, S., Cantante, I., Folques, D., & Campos, R. (2025). ClaimPT annotation guidelines.
https://github.com/LIAAD/ClaimPT/blob/main/ClaimPT%20Annotation%20Manual.pdf

Thorne, J., Vlachos, A., Christodoulopoulos, C., & Mittal, A. (2018). FEVER: A large-scale dataset for fact extraction and VERification. In Proceedings of the 2018 Conference of the North American Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics: Human Language Technologies, Volume 1 (Long Papers) (pp. 809–819). Association for Computational Linguistics. https://doi.org/10.18653/v1/N18-1074